OSHA Excavation Checklist (29 CFR 1926.651)

For the competent person's inspection before work, during the shift as needed, and after rain or other hazard-increasing events.

OSHA 29 CFR 1926.651

DATE	SHIFT
INSPECTOR	AREA / EQUIPMENT ID

Before you start

1. Mark every item OK, Defect or N/A.
2. If an item is a Defect, record it and, where it creates a hazardous condition, remove exposed employees from the area until precautions are in place (1926.651(k)(2)).
3. Equipment manufacturers' instructions, site rules and other Subpart P sections may add checks.

Legal basis: 29 CFR 1926.651: Specific excavation requirements (Part 1926 Subpart P: Excavations) Source: eCFR, Title 29, text as of 2026-11-09
Online version and sources: https://safetyindex.blog/us/standards/1926-651-excavation

SECTION A | Utilities, surface hazards and adjoining structures

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
1	Surface encumbrances Ref. 1926.651(a)	Anything at the surface that could endanger employees has been removed or supported	☐	☐	☐	
2	Utility locations estimated Ref. 1926.651(b)(1)	Estimated locations of sewer, telephone, fuel, electric, water and other underground lines determined before the excavation was opened	☐	☐	☐	
3	Utility owners contacted Ref. 1926.651(b)(2)	Utility companies or owners contacted within established or customary local response times, advised of the proposed work and asked to establish the location of their installations before excavation started	☐	☐	☐	
4	Proceeding without a locate Ref. 1926.651(b)(2)	Where owners could not respond within 24 hours (or a longer period required by state or local law) or could not establish the exact location, work proceeds with caution and with detection equipment or other acceptable means in use	☐	☐	☐	
5	Exact location near lines Ref. 1926.651(b)(3)	Exact location confirmed by safe and acceptable means as digging nears the estimated location	☐	☐	☐	
6	Exposed utilities Ref. 1926.651(b)(4)	Exposed underground installations protected, supported or removed	☐	☐	☐	
7	Adjoining structures Ref. 1926.651(i)(1)	Shoring, bracing or underpinning in place where buildings, walls or other structures are endangered	☐	☐	☐	
8	Digging below footings Ref. 1926.651(i)(2)	No excavation below a foundation or retaining wall footing unless one of the conditions in 1926.651(i)(2)(i)–(iv) is met	☐	☐	☐	
9	Sidewalks and pavement Ref. 1926.651(i)(3)	Not undermined, or a support system or other protection is provided	☐	☐	☐	

General guidance only, not legal advice. Check the current regulation and your employer's procedures.

SECTION B | Access, egress and crossings

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
10	Trench egress Ref. 1926.651(c)(2)	In trenches 4 feet (1.22 m) or deeper, a stairway, ladder, ramp or other safe egress within 25 feet (7.62 m) of lateral travel for every employee	☐	☐	☐	
11	Employee ramp design Ref. 1926.651(c)(1)(i)	Structural ramps used only by employees designed by a competent person	☐	☐	☐	
12	Equipment ramp design Ref. 1926.651(c)(1)(i)	Equipment ramps designed by a competent person qualified in structural design and built to that design	☐	☐	☐	
13	Ramp members connected Ref. 1926.651(c)(1)(ii)	Ramp and runway members joined so they cannot shift	☐	☐	☐	
14	Member thickness Ref. 1926.651(c)(1)(iii)	Ramp and runway members of uniform thickness	☐	☐	☐	
15	Runway cleats Ref. 1926.651(c)(1)(iv)	Connecting cleats fixed under the runway or placed so they are not a trip hazard	☐	☐	☐	
16	Ramp surface Ref. 1926.651(c)(1)(v)	Ramps used instead of steps have cleats or a non-slip top surface	☐	☐	☐	
17	Walkways Ref. 1926.651(l)	Walkways provided wherever employees or equipment cross over the excavation	☐	☐	☐	
18	Walkway guardrails Ref. 1926.651(l)	Guardrails on walkways 6 feet (1.8 m) or more above lower levels	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION C | Traffic, loads, equipment and falling material

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
19	High-visibility garments Ref. 1926.651(d)	Employees exposed to public traffic wearing reflectorized or high-visibility vests or garments	☐	☐	☐	
20	No one under loads Ref. 1926.651(e)	Nobody beneath loads handled by lifting or digging equipment	☐	☐	☐	
21	Clear of loading vehicles Ref. 1926.651(e)	Employees standing away from vehicles being loaded or unloaded	☐	☐	☐	
22	Mobile equipment warning system Ref. 1926.651(f)	Barricades, hand or mechanical signals, or stop logs in use where operators near the edge lack a clear and direct view of it	☐	☐	☐	
23	Spoil and equipment setback Ref. 1926.651(j)(2)	Excavated material and equipment 2 feet (.61 m) or more back from the edge, or retaining devices holding them	☐	☐	☐	
24	Loose rock or soil on the face Ref. 1926.651(j)(1)	Face scaled, protective barricades installed, or equivalent protection against falling or rolling material	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION D | Atmosphere and water

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
25	Atmosphere tested Ref. 1926.651(g)(1)(i)	Where a hazardous or oxygen-deficient atmosphere could exist, air tested before entry into excavations greater than 4 feet deep	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION D | Atmosphere and water

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
26	Oxygen and contaminant controls Ref. 1926.651(g)(1)(ii)	Ventilation or respiratory protection in place where oxygen is below 19.5 percent or the atmosphere is hazardous	☐	☐	☐	
27	Flammable gas Ref. 1926.651(g)(1)(iii)	Ventilation or other precautions keep exposure from exceeding 20 percent of the lower flammable limit	☐	☐	☐	
28	Retesting with controls Ref. 1926.651(g)(1)(iv)	Atmosphere retested as often as needed while controls are relied on	☐	☐	☐	
29	Rescue equipment Ref. 1926.651(g)(2)(i)	Breathing apparatus, harness and line, basket stretcher or similar readily available where hazardous atmospheres exist or may develop, and attended when in use	☐	☐	☐	
30	Pier hole lifelines Ref. 1926.651(g)(2)(ii)	Employees in bell-bottom pier holes or similar deep confined footings wear a harness with a separate, individually attended lifeline	☐	☐	☐	
31	Accumulated water Ref. 1926.651(h)(1)	No work in standing or accumulating water unless precautions such as shield systems, water removal or harness and lifeline are in place	☐	☐	☐	
32	Water removal monitored Ref. 1926.651(h)(2)	A competent person monitors pumps and water removal operations	☐	☐	☐	
33	Surface water diverted Ref. 1926.651(h)(3)	Diversion ditches, dikes or other means keep surface water out where natural drainage is interrupted	☐	☐	☐	
34	Runoff from heavy rains Ref. 1926.651(h)(3)	Excavations subject to heavy-rain runoff inspected by a competent person, with (h)(1) and (h)(2) met	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION E | Competent person inspection

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
35	Inspection scope Ref. 1926.651(k)(1)	Excavation, adjacent areas and protective systems checked for signs of cave-in, protective system failure, hazardous atmospheres and other hazards	☐	☐	☐	
36	Inspection timing Ref. 1926.651(k)(1)	Inspection done before work started and repeated as needed during the shift	☐	☐	☐	
37	After rain or other events Ref. 1926.651(k)(1)	Re-inspection completed after every rainstorm or other hazard-increasing occurrence	☐	☐	☐	
38	Employees removed from hazards Ref. 1926.651(k)(2)	Exposed employees kept out of any area where a hazard was found until precautions are taken	☐	☐	☐	

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DEFECTS FOUND AND ACTION TAKEN

Item no.	Defect description	Reported to	Action taken / date closed

SIGN-OFF

SAFE TO OPERATE?	☐ Yes ☐ No: tagged out of service	
INSPECTOR SIGNATURE		DATE / TIME
SUPERVISOR REVIEW		DATE / TIME